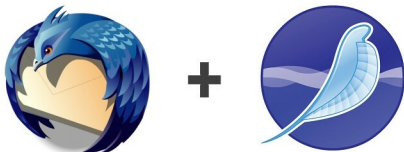


Tricks to Try Out on Thunderbird and SeaMonkey

Learn to use and store email messages offline with Thunderbird and SeaMonkey.



In 2004, Google introduced its Gmail service with a 1GB mailbox and free POP access. This was at a time when most people had email accounts with their ISP or had free Web mail accounts with Hotmail or Yahoo. Mailbox storage was limited to measly amounts such as 5MB or 10MB. If you did not regularly purge old messages, then your incoming mail would bounce with the dreaded 'Inbox full' error. Hence, it was a standard practice to store email 'offline' using an email client. Each year now, a new generation of young people (mostly students) discover the Internet and they start with Web mail straight away. As popular Web mail services integrate online chatting as well, they prefer to use a Web browser rather than a desktop mail client to access email. This is sad because desktop email clients represent one of those rare Internet technologies that can claim to have achieved perfection. This article will bring readers up to speed on Thunderbird, the most popular FOSS email client.

Why use a desktop email client?

With an email client, you store emails offline. After the email application connects to your mail server and downloads new mail, it instructs the server to delete those messages from your mailbox (unless configured otherwise). This has several advantages.

- If your account gets hacked, the hacker will not get your archived messages. This also limits the fallout on your other accounts such as those of online banking.
- Web mail providers such as Gmail read your messages to display 'relevant' advertisements. This is creepy, even if it is software-driven.
- Email clients let you read and compose messages offline. A working Net connection is not required. Web mail requires you to log in first.
- Web mail providers such as Gmail automatically

tell your contacts whether you are online or if your camera is on. Email clients do not do this.

- Modern Web browsers take many liberties without asking. Chrome, by default, listens to your microphone and uploads conversations to Google servers (for your convenience of course). Email clients are not like that.
- Searching archived messages is extremely powerful on desktop mail clients. There is no paging of the results.
- When popular Web mail providers offer free POP access, why suffer the slowness of the Web?

POP or IMAP access to email

Email clients use two protocols, POP and IMAP, to receive mail. POP is ideal if you want to download and delete mail. IMAP is best if you need access on multiple devices or at different locations. POP is more prevalent than IMAP. For offline storage, POP is the best. Popular Web mail providers provide both POP and IMAP access. Before you can use an email client, you will have to log in to your Web mail provider in a browser, check the settings and activate POP/IMAP access for incoming mail. Email clients use the SMTP protocol for outgoing mail. In Thunderbird/SeaMonkey, you may have to add SMTP server settings separately for each email account.

If you have lots of email already online, then it may not be possible to make your email client create an offline copy in one go. Each time you choose to receive messages, the mail client will download a few hundred of your old messages. After it has downloaded all your old archived messages, the mail client will then settle down to downloading only your newest messages.

The settings for some popular Web mail services are as follows:

- Hotmail/Live/Outlook